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Bob Kinkel

Keyboardist and producer Bob Kinkel is a 1979 graduate of Hamilton College. His piano and physics studies, along with an active curiosity in how things work, prepared him well for a diverse career in the music business. Bob has worked at the Record Plant, been active in session work and jingle writing, and with partners Jon Oliva and Paul O'Neill, transformed an idea for a rock opera into the phenomenally successful Trans-Siberian Orchestra.

Bob was interviewed in Clinton, New York, on October 31, 2012, by Monk Rowe, director of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm off camera talking to Bob Kinkel, a Hamilton alum, sitting in the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. Thanks for being here.

BK: My pleasure. Good to see you.

MR: I've been watching some videos of the Trans-Siberian Orchestra, and it makes me wonder how you can still hear me, for one thing, and whether you have some battle scars, or whatever.

BK: Yeah, no burns, no nothing. Actually when we play live most of us have in-ears, which is basically they take a mold of your ear and it's like having earplugs in that are also headphones, so you can be up there and listen pretty much as quiet as you want, and just sit there and hear a nice stereo mix of the band. So it's not very loud, for me. And, you know all the pyro and stuff going off doesn't really make that much noise.

MR: Boy it sure does look like it.

BK: Oh yeah. It's powerful. It's a powerful effect, and the front of the house PA system puts out some — a big oomph. You try to make it not too loud. You try to keep it so it's not much louder than like a movie presentation. Because we don't want people to have hearing damage and all that. So it's very carefully planned that way. So it sounds big, full, has an impact, you feel it in your chest, but no it doesn't hurt anybody.

MR: I'm glad you guys are aware of that.

BK: Oh very, very.

MR: I'm sure you have a mixed-age audience too. The parents want to be able to bring their families and all that kind of stuff.

BK: Yeah, a lot do. There is, often you see like three generations out there. I mean a lot of grandparents are rockers — if you figure out, let's see Woodstock was in what, 1968, and you know, add another 44 years to that. So most rockers from that era are in their 60's and 70's.

MR: I've noticed that because sometimes I play gigs at retirement homes, and people really perk up when you start to play some rhythm & blues and some rock & roll.

BK: Oh yeah.

MR: It took me a while to get used to that. It used to be Glenn Miller that would get them.

BK: Yeah.

MR: But that whole —

BK: Yeah, now their youth is the Stones and the Who, and all that stuff. Yeah, I remember listening to the radio when I was growing up and there was always a big band on the old people station. Now it's old rock. But it's also great that kids today listen to the same music a lot. There's a ton of new stuff but just because of the accessibility of recording and the way that's all worked you have really good access to the music your parents listened to, so you can pick and choose what you hear, and it's so easy to carry it around you know. Twenty days of music on a little thing, a little iPod or something.

MR: Well if you meet someone at a party or whatever, someone that doesn't know you, and they ask you what do you do, do you have a short answer for them?

BK: What do I do? I just say like I'm a music producer. It depends on the party, because sometimes you just want to have fun at the party. But, you know, I'll say musician, producer, and I'll say one of my most recent successful projects is the Trans-Siberian Orchestra, which I was one of the creators of that with — Paul O'Neill and Jon Oliva were the main people — Paul kind of spearheading the project.

MR: Right. Did you have those — it's sometimes hard to look back at the time when you might have thought what your career was going to be. But when you were at Hamilton you were a music major?

BK: Um hum.

MR: Did you have thoughts about, okay, post-Hamilton what am I going to do in music?

BK: I kind of knew by end that I wanted to be going into the recording aspect, the production aspect of music. I had, on campus I had the campus band for my junior and senior year called Rogue, and we were playing all the house parties and doing that. And we had started to write some original stuff. And I had actually stayed up here a year after I graduated. I graduated in '79 so I stayed up one further year. We were trying to see if we could keep the band together and do something with it. And that kind of didn't work out too well. But I ended up working for the Physics Department putting all the labs together for them, and I was the organist in the chapel. So that kind of kept me busy. And you know, just doing music, reading everything about it, and I ended up, you know I kind of had that goal in mind and I was still a little naïve of what you really needed to be a recording engineer or something, I figured you had to have an electrical engineering degree and all that stuff. I remember near the — earlier in the spring of 1980 I was working with Jim Ring and Phil Pearle and Peter Millet in the Physics Department. And Jim Ring asked me, he goes, "so what are you doing next year?" And I go, "oh, I'm not

really sure." And he goes, "do you want to go to Columbia?" Because I guess they have a four-two program with Hamilton and Columbia. So I put in an application and they called me up and said, "oh we'd love to have you" and I was awarded a full fellowship for studying solid state physics at Columbia.

MR: Solid state physics?

BK: Solid state physics deals with — it's in the material science aspect of that. So I went down and did that, and about halfway through the program decided I really didn't like it and I wanted to get into music.

MR: Well at the time there was — I don't think there was much of an opportunity to go and study how to be a recording engineer. Now you have Full Sail Recording School, and most music schools have programs for that. Was apprenticeship something that you aspired to?

BK: Yeah, that was really the only way to do it, and the bigger studios had a system in place for training people. And at the time it was — Record Plant and Power Station were the two biggest studios in New York. They were cranking out all the hits that you'd be hearing at the time. And I had met, now a good friend of mine, Jim Ball, through like a convoluted thing, which, everybody's contacts always come through some kind of convoluted thing. It was Andy Burns, who grew up in Clinton, was good friends with Jim Ball, who grew up in Clinton, and Andy was my second cousin's roommate, who went to Hamilton, and I met them at a party in New York and Jim was working at Record Plant. And so he introduced me to the studio manager at the time. And so I went in and met them, you know, gave them my resume, and they said, "oh we don't have anything," and I said "I'll work for free." And then basically I came back every two weeks for six months saying, "hey, what's going on, how you doing, I'll work for free." And they started to get to know me and I started to get to know people around there, and then eventually I think they had an intern from some other school there like three days a week so I just went in and said, "oh, what about the other two, I'll work those days." And they go, "okay." I guess persistence paid off. So I started doing that. And then once I was in there, I worked for free for a few months, I was like helping the carpenter, you know, move walls, paint, I worked in the maintenance shop. I remember I made thousands of mic cables because they had two recording trucks and they were redoing all their cables for those. And, you know, I followed the maintenance guys around. I would sit with the assistant engineers when they would do their practice sessions. So I learned the rooms. You know, I was there like 80 hours a week.

MR: How did you pay your rent?

BK: Well I was actually, luckily, living at my girlfriend's mom's house in Brooklyn Heights and just paid her like minimal rent. But I also had taken out a student loan right before I

left to kind of get me through the gap, which I totally paid back. Because it was considered like internships and working for super low amounts of money is, basically you're either going to school for free or your getting paid something to go to school. I can think of it as a stipend. Because so many people, they will go to a Full Sail or one of these places and they get out and expect to be making money, but it doesn't matter what you do you're still at the bottom when you come out. And you might be working for free or you might be making $150 a week travel money and stuff like that. There's just not a lot of money at the beginning. So you have to look at it as going to school more, and continuing that. So that's always been my way of justifying it.

MR: So can I imagine it was a big deal the first time you got up to like set up microphones or something, for some band, and be in the midst of it?

BK: Yeah. As I said, I was — the way Record Plant worked is the assistant engineers basically were — you had to be almost as good as an engineer to be an assistant at Record Plant. Actually can we take one second? I just need to blow my nose.

MR: Sure.

BK: Where were we?

MR: We were talking about, sort of that entrance into —

BK: Yeah. I mean it was exciting at Record Plant from the day I walked in there. Because there were four studios plus two remote trucks at Record Plant. So they were always doing something with the top people, like if you walked in the door, on the ground floor to the left was Studio B and the day I started Cyndi Lauper was doing her debut record in Studio B; J. Geils Band was up in the mix room doing the "Freeze Frame" album, which was like their multi-platinum hit; I think Willie Nile was in another room; you'd have like Joan Jett; you'd have like everybody would be there. And it was just, you know, everybody was just walking around and hanging out. So it was like all of a sudden you're just in the midst of it. And again, they had a really nice training program. It wasn't specifically called a training program, but they wanted their people to be tops. So an assistant engineer had to know the room inside and out, every single patch point you had memorized, every patch point, every knob, what that did, how every piece of outboard worked, everything in the studio, as an assistant you had to know how to do that. And the assistants would punch in for recording. The engineer didn't do that, the assistants at the Record Plant would do all the punches. So it was just like really learning from the top people. And as I said, I was helping the assistants do that, so I'd learn the rooms. They said you've got to memorize the patch bay, memorize the patch bays in all four rooms, how everything was patched around there, and plus I was going around with the maintenance guys just tagging along and watched them align a tape machine and like by

the next day I could do it, because I have so much technical background, that tech stuff was cake for me.

MR: So that was a help, the stuff you did here?

BK: Oh yeah, it was very much. I did a lot of electronic music work here. They used to have a four-track Scully and a two-track Revox, and one of the big Arp modular synthesizers and I had a mini-Moog that I bought my senior year in high school, so I knew analog synthesis inside and out. And Hugh Hartwell, who was the teacher for my freshman year when I took the electronic music course, he goes, "if you learn how to edit tape you can always get a job in a recording studio." And I got really, really good at editing here and so there I was so good at editing that the producer and the engineer would walk off and they'd leave me with all the master mixes of the tapes and say, "uh, cut the other record, we'll be back." Or they'd say, because in those days it was before they had automated mixes, so every mix would be a performance, and you would like mix the first part, the second part, and then you'd kind of listen back and you'd take the best parts of the mixes and cut them together to make your final mix of the songs. So they would leave me that and they wouldn't even tell me, they'd just say, "cut it together."

MR: No kidding.

BK: So I got to do a lot of that, and, backtracking a little, I'd been working for free, learning all this stuff from the assistants, and people there, and all of a sudden when I walked in one day they go, "Roy wants to work with you." And Roy Cicala was the owner of Record Plant. He was John Lennon's engineer. He goes way, way back. He's just an amazing, amazing engineer. And so he pulled me in, and he always had a band that he was working with, kind of a pet project and also for training people. And so he brought me into a session and he was a very low-key guy. And he basically would pretend he doesn't know things. He will like set up a feedback loop on the console that's one button away from like blowing your head off if you press the wrong button. And he'd go, "I want to record a vocal on track 22. I push this button, right?" And that would be the button of death. And you'd have like two seconds to say like no, no, no, no, not that. That would cause a feedback loop. And if you didn't he would just push it, and just sit there and go, "oh, that's nice." So you'd have like 120 dB of feedback coming at you.

MR: Was that his way of like testing you to see if you knew what you were doing?

BK: Yeah. And the next day I was hired because I didn't let him do that.

MR: Oh that is so cool. You know I recall, I did some studio work and I don't think I ever spliced any tape, but the first time I ever saw tape spliced, I thought it was the damnedest thing. You mean you can cut that and put this piece in, and you can't tell.

BK: Um hum. If you do it right. Yeah.

MR: Were you using two-inch machines?

BK: Yeah they were two-inch machines. They would lock up, they had a way of synchronizing multiple 24-tracks, so most of the mixes by the time I was there started being 48-track, well actually 46-track because you had to have time code to lock them up together.

MR: Did you ever think, at that time, I'm not sure how to phrase this, but, did you ever experience better recordings that had fewer tracks, because you had to make better decisions?

BK: It's all about, kind of, decisions. I've been teaching a class, "Topics in Music," and part of it we went back through a lot of recording history and how things worked like in Motown days almost all those recordings are three-track where they would pre-mix to one-track of the machine and then they would do a session and record like brass on another, winds on another, and then they would take those three tracks and bounce it with like a live recording of strings, and there'd be background vocals, and then they'd mix that to another machine and record the lead vocals, and then have your final thing together. So all the pre-mix stages had to be, that was it. Your decision was made, it was done. And as the number of tracks started increasing, basically all it did was postpone when the decisions and the commitments were made. And so in the class I like showed them how a four-track of the Beatles, you know, "Sergeant Pepper's" was four track; Led Zeppelin, like "Whole Lot of Love" was an eight-track; then you get to "Bohemian Rhapsody" which was 24-track, and where you have things, you use like one track for many different things and then you bring it up to different channels on a mixing console. And again, everything was by hand, punching things in and out, moving things around, twisting knobs, and that was how you did your mix. And then automation started showing up, you know, mid-80's. That was kind of usable automation. So then you could listen to a mix and it would play back exactly the same the next time, because all the faders would be moved for you, and eventually that let you get the perfectionist guy in there a little more, so things became less of performances and more of a repeatable thing. And now it's down to mixing in the box, a lot of people do, where it's instantly recallable. Your mix is right there and you can say, "I couldn't hear," you know, "the third word in the second line of the third verse," and you just went "bink" and that's all you have to do, and reprint your mix and you're done.

MR: Is it good? Is it a good thing?

BK: It can be. It can be. It's all how, my view of technology and the way it's gotten so much easier to do it in all forms, like, you know, graphic design, art, music recording, it's really easy to get to high mediocrity. And unfortunately that is like where a lot of people stay and it's very rare that people are popping above that with any kind of design. It's like I'm happy that a lot of the top architectural schools are making everybody do stuff by hand

again before they'll let them take whatever design they did by hand and put into CAD programs. So it's more using it as a tool instead of the creative crutch, because it's so easy to get — yeah, it's easy to get high mediocrity.

MR: I'm going to quote you on that, that's a great way to put it. So, any particular memorable encounters with some of the musicians, the bands, during your tenure there?

BK: After I was there for about a year I was lucky to go on tour with the Who. We did, it was their first final tour in 1982. Well it's a Who final tour. I still have all the swag from that. But I was the tape op. Basically Glyn Johns is like using these huge Altec speakers for his — so I had to figure out a way to fit those into the big truck, it was a, we called it Black Peter, it was a big Peterbuilt Truck, a beautiful truck with an API console, and just decked out hardwood and stuff, just a gorgeous looking truck. But I had to figure out a way to get these monitors in there in front. So I built this thing out of wood and fit it together and knew how to set it up so the speakers would sit there kind of on shelves and fit. So because I put that together I got to go, plus they knew I knew all that tech stuff and could do that. That was great. So I got to hang in the truck with Glyn Johns and he would get the mix up and tell stories. So that was like my first —

MR: Were they recording every live concert?

BK: They were recording all the stadium shows, and a couple of the smaller ones. But it was basically just going around to stadiums all over the country, and I got to fly around, which was great, because I didn't know how to drive the truck. Sometimes that's an advantage.

MR: That sounds like a cool experience.

BK: Yeah, that was wonderful. And then, working with a live truck you got to work with a lot of different people — you know, Genesis — anybody who was popular during the 80's we recorded live. There were these live shows like "King Biscuit Flour Hour" and things like that, which would be live recordings of the bands, and Record Plant would do most of them. So we were out there all the time.

MR: Were your friends in the business jealous of what you were doing?

BK: I don't know. My friends became people I was working with there so, not really, because everybody's working with somebody at that point. Some of them were jealous that had been there for a while, because we did a broadcast from Toronto for the Who at the end of the tour, it was huge. In those days, you know, there wasn't pay-per-view, there wasn't cable TV really, except for a better way to get your antennae up. So all the big events were kind of projected live in clubs for like the big concerts and things like that. So it would be like all live in theaters, clubs and all that, and so we were doing that and I got a full screen credit for that thing as being a tape op, so they were kind of —

MR: Well it just occurred to me that about the time you stayed your extra year here at Hamilton, you said that was 1980?

BK: Yes. '79-'80.

MR: At that same time I was in a progressive rock band in this area. And people, I think most of us had this concept of we want to make it big, you know, whatever that meant. We weren't sure what it meant, but it certainly meant not playing just in central New York. But then of course we were all trying to score a record deal.

BK: Right.

MR: Whatever, we probably weren't even sure what that meant except that we would have a record. And it seems like most musicians are always trying to get to the next level. And when I hear your story, you went to the next level, but maybe it wasn't what you thought it would be. But it ended up —

BK: Yeah, you just keep following the way to go. And I mean I went from working at Record Plant and assisting on records. I worked with Jack Douglas on an Aerosmith record, I got to work with Dave Thoner, with Don Was — like one of the first records was Was (Not Was). And so I got to work on the mix with that, and just see how it's done, and everybody's sitting there on the console for the mix, just moving faders, doing that. So I learned a lot from a lot of different people who were all at the top of their game, not to mention Roy Cicala before, just learning their techniques, how they'd do it, how you record a vocal. So I learned all that, and then I also could read music, I was also a player, they had some really nice Steinways in all the rooms, so downtime or whatever I'd just sit there and break out Beethoven and play etudes or whatever. So I was playing a lot, keeping my chops up. I was still into synthesis. I actually started renting keyboards within the — I think I had a Rhodes and bought a Prophet-5 and all that, so I rented to sessions. They were nice enough to let me do that, so I was kind of entrepreneurial there. And I started playing out in local bands and stuff. Like in New York you're never in one band, you're always in like about five different ones and everybody's playing at different times. That's just the way it worked. So I got a lot of experience doing that. And just like one day, I think it was a jingle session or something, and the guy would like re-program his sound in between each section, because it had to go from one sound to another sound. So he would like program back and forth. And they had a score there and I said, "I can just punch around that," you know, "just keep the one sound and play and I'll punch it in other sections and then change the sound and I'll punch it into the other," which didn't endear me to him because I think he was going for some overtime on the session. And then there were other times where, working with some band and like he was trying to play a keyboard part and it's like four hours later I realized I could have had this done in ten minutes. And so I started saying well maybe I should start playing on sessions. And I

met Charlie Morrow, was one of the clients at Record Plant, and he had like an event business and he also did jingles. He was kind of on the fringe of the jingle industry. And one day we were just talking about synthesis and the future of how that's going, and that and computer music, and where that is all going to, and he said, "oh I've got this jingle project, do you want to work on it with me?" And it was like kind of just doing a video version of the sounder for 10-10 WINS. But it was fun. And then he said, "oh I've got this other thing." It was — this agency had sent out a thing to all the music houses, so it was a competition among every single music house that was in New York or probably the country. It was for Hefty trash bags. And basically I just gave lyrics, which was "hefty, hefty, hefty/wimpy, wimpy, wimpy." And that was all it said on it. And Charlie had this one idea, and I worked with him on that. And we recorded this thing in his 8-track studio and we won. That was it. And all of a sudden I started making money with SAG residuals, because it was our voices going "hefty, hefty, hefty." So we were both getting double solo scale because we double-tracked ourselves. And it was like, I was happy, I made like four hundred dollars, and then all the residual checks started coming in and like all of a sudden, you know this thing ran for five years and it turned into hundreds of thousands of dollars. And it was like wow — I won the lottery. So that was great. It kind of allowed me to feed my equipment habit and things like that.

MR: That's so interesting. I mean you think about guys like — was it Neal Hefti who wrote "Batman?" And you know, probably the quickest thing he ever wrote and he probably made more money off that than the great Basie charts and all that stuff. And you guys were probably laughing when you were doing this "hefty/hefty/hefty."

BK: Oh yeah, we had a great time. Charlie was shorter than me so to do that I had him stand on a chair so we'd be like the same height on the mic, and slowed down the tape machine to do the "wimpys" and then sped it back up. And you know, I knew all the recording tricks. I knew all the production stuff. Plus I knew the music. So it worked really well. Like I wasn't the best player in the world, I wasn't the best engineer, but I did everything really, really well. So I could just go in and take care of any situation.

MR: Did you have to learn to deal with the clients who wanted something from the music but they couldn't really tell you what it was?

BK: Yeah. You would deal with that. You kind of figure out, like if you're working with a picture you kind of figure out what works and a lot of times they'll give you like reference things, which is, something like, kind of like this piece of music, they'll give you an idea sometimes of what they're looking for, and sometimes you'll give them something totally different that they hadn't thought of and they go, "Whoa, that's even better." You know.

MR: What about hiring other session players? Was that a part of what you did?

BK: A little bit. Not as much. If it was something I was doing with Charlie or something I was more involved in production on, yeah, you need a guitar part you'd call in like Elliot Randall or someone to come in. It was fun. I did like a lot of just showing up as a keyboard player to sessions too, and you never knew if you'd be on the session. So like Steve Gadd would be there, you know, "yeah, how you doing." "Good." "Okay, see you, I've got to go do some dog food thing in ten minutes." And so there was a lot of the working musician stuff there so you would cross paths with a lot of the, again, heroes.

MR: As a session player, you rarely knew what you were going to be called on to play, music-wise, is that correct?

BK: That's very correct. And usually the people who hired me, the contractors, would know what you do, so I was like a synthesizer specialist but I also played piano a bit. So depending on what it was I got to get called for whatever it. I used to have, you know like a Prophet-5, a DX-7 and a few modules and stuff, all built into racks, and they'd have these people that would move your equipment for you, called cartage people, it was great. They would come to my studio, break it all down, you know I rewired all my stuff so everything was on multi-pin connectors, and they'd take it down, pack it up, take it to the studio for me, set it all up, so basically I walked in and it's all ready to go. Everything, you just go — play whatever they need, and then just go, "I'm done." Pack it up and take it over to the next session.

MR: Let me see how you would have dealt with this situation. I had a session once where a guy had me play one note on the sax. He wanted one note. And I did it right the first time. In other words, this whole thing might have taken 15 minutes. Now when someone asked, if you had done something like that and said, "well what's your charge for this?" Do you charge them hardly anything, because you did it in 15 minutes, or do you charge them more because you just saved them studio time?

BK: Well in the commercial world, and what I was doing, it all falls under the union rules. So it was by the hour. So like I would show up and they'd go, "what we need here is a woosh." And I'd just go, "woosh." And being a keyboard player, multi keyboards and stuff, you always get double scale. So I got double scale for going in and playing a woosh. Or sometimes you would be there for hours and hours. But they set up the scale system just for those things.

MR: So you're not in a position, I mean around here the union wasn't involved in any of that, so you wouldn't be in that kind of position where the guy paying the bill might think, well, you weren't here very long.

BK: You just played a note, but then you also, you have to get there. I mean the majority of the time for doing a local session you have to get there, you have to be warmed up, you have to be ready to play anything, and that's what they're paying you for. They're not

paying you for your note, you know. What was the old — was that a Saturday Night Live skit where they were doing the Mr. Rogers take-off with the bass player? And he's going yeah, I'm just thinking about how much I get paid for notes. No, it doesn't work like that. You know, they're paying you for your expertise and whatever you're doing, you're playing whatever part they need.

MR: Do you still do this?

BK: No. Not very much. I'll play on stuff that I'm producing, or friends of mine that I'm producing I'll go in and play piano parts or orchestrate things. I still record. I have a studio in Long Island City, Queens, and it's part of another big complex that I also have a part interest in, so we have like a huge 72 input SSL board with a big recording room and then I've got another whole Pro Tools system in the back that's all in the digital world, and you know it's like racks of guitars and just like a whole credenza full of synthesizer modules and like all the latest toys.

MR: You have to — it's important that you like and enjoy technology, isn't it? Is that an understatement?

BK: The way I particularly work, yes. But a lot of friends of mine are just — you know they understand it enough to be able to converse with the engineers and stuff, and tell them what they want. There's people who know the tech stuff and part of their job is to translate what musicians have in mind into geek tech-talk to make it work. So if you're not a tech guy and something sounds dull, you say, "that sounds a little dull." And then the engineers are, "oh, I've got to bring up the top end." You know, stuff like that. You don't need to talk to them in technical terms. You can use words like punchy and, you know, punchy-dull, make it more exciting. You can say things like that. But I happen to do all of it.

MR: Right. Well the whole thing with the Trans-Siberian Orchestra had this sort of path from the heavy metal band into this Christmas-oriented — I guess it's a seasonal —

BK: Well it started off seasonal but it's become kind of a year-round thing. That — again I was doing session work and I had left Record Plant but, you know, all my connections I'd made there were still there. Paul O'Neill, who was the main guy in TSO, was doing his first record with a band called Savatage, which is the metal band that TSO kind of spun off of. You know, the same creative core went and formed Trans-Siberian Orchestra. And this was in the mid-80's. They were doing "Hall of the Mountain King." And I got a call from my friend Jim, who was the guy who introduced me to Record Plant to begin with, saying, "oh I'm with this guy, he wants to do an orchestra kind of thing. Can you do that like with your sampled stuff? Can you do like a whole orchestral part?" I go, "yeah, no problem." And so I brought in my Emulator-2, with all my stuff, I brought it in and they were doing "Hall of the Mountain King." You know, Grieg. So it was like, and there was

this piece they were doing that was kind of war between the rock band and the orchestra. So basically I went and played every single part one at a time, of the orchestra, but it was a more in-your-face type of sound because it was a keyboard thing. But it also had a realism to it because if there was five string lines I'd play it with five different sounds and layer it all together. So you could have done it with people, but I was there, and I just did it, and it was a way of making it really tight-sounding. So that was the first time. And then I ended up playing a bunch of stuff on the rest of the record, and then he started calling me back, for any record he did I would come in and play keyboards on. And in the early 90's we started writing together, because he always heard me noodling and he went, "oh, he's got some good stuff."

MR: Kind of like Duke Ellington. He used to listen to his players noodle, you know.

BK: Oh yeah?

MR: Yeah. He would listen to his people warm up and he'd go, "hmmm, I think I like that.' [scats].

BK: Yeah. So anyway, we started writing and we wrote a musical called "Romanov, When Kings Must Whisper," and a couple of other things. And meantime Paul had this idea for doing something with "Carol of the Bells," and he had a guitar intro for "God Rest Ye Merry Gentlemen." And we worked on that together for a while, and then Christmas Eve Sarajevo 12/24" came out of that. You know we wrote some original music too, and combined it with the well-known carols and created that piece. And then Al Pitrelli added some guitar stuff and that all of a sudden became a hit. It just went — the first time it was originally on a Savatage record called "Dead Winter Dead" which was about that conflict in Bosnia. And you know the rest of it was like real head-banging metal, but this one thing, there was a guy called Mason Dixon, down in Tampa. And the band Savatage was from Tampa. And he saw this little sampler CD of Savatage, and he goes, "oh, I know these guys." And he listened to it and just loved that track, "Christmas Eve Sarajevo." So he put it on the air and the lights lit up, everybody called in, "what the hell is that, we love it." And from that he called his friend Scott Shannon in New York City who is the program director and main DJ for WPLJ which was at the time the absolute largest radio listening audience. And we heard that he had gotten it and was going to play it in the next three days or so. So I got up every morning at six when their show started, and put a cassette in the recorder and just kept flipping it, for three days. And finally it came on. He started talking about it. He read, there was like a story, Paul writes these amazing stories and he writes all the lyrics and co-writes all the music. He's an amazingly creative guy. But anyway, they read the whole story he wrote about it, which was about a cello player in the square in Sarajevo that would go in and play cello amidst the rubble, just to show that man is alive, or still human, and at Christmastime he played Christmas carols. So the

song starts out with the cello solo playing "God Rest Ye Merry Gentlemen" with a guitar ostinato. Anyway, so he read the whole story, and it was like boy-girl on each side, and hear the music and come together, and it's just like part of the healing process for peace. And he read the whole thing and then they played the song, and then he started talking about it. So it got like ten minutes of airtime on the song. And then of course the phones lit up there too, so they started playing it regularly. And it spread to Cleveland that year, and then the next year we made Trans-Siberian Orchestra, the label, that, "can you do a whole record of this stuff?"

MR: And your first performance of this music occurred when?

BK: There was one quick performance we did down in Tampa for like it was called the "World's Biggest Office Party." But that was as Savatage, we played "Christmas Eve Sarajevo" for the first time. And then we also would play live on the radio. PLJ has, their pet charity is a childrens' hospital, and I'm spacing on the name of it — I can't remember — and every year they have live music with a lot of top acts, and they asked us to do that. So we were there ridiculously early in the morning playing. And we'd do appearances on Rosie O'Donnell or Conan O'Brien — a few TV shows — Good Morning America, that kind of thing. And then the first tour was in 1999. We just did a quick, it was a seven show tour. It was supposed to be four. We had no idea if anyone wanted to hear us or not, live, and we put the first show on in Cleveland. And Bill Lewis, who is the program director and DJ there was just a huge supporter. He was the one pushing us really, to tour. That first show went on sale and Cleveland sold out in an hour. So we put two more shows on sale in Cleveland and they both — boom, boom, went out. So instead of a four show tour it was — no instead of a five show tour it was a seven show tour, where we just did New York, Philly, three in Cleveland going there and back, and switching venues in the middle — you had to go play one venue one night, move everything to another one, play in that venue, Detroit and Chicago.

MR: Did the orchestra get larger, and the tech thing get larger every year?

BK: Every year we tended to add a truck worth of production. So the very first tour was two tour buses, one for the band and one for the crew, and one truck. And now they're up to six tour buses for the crew, three for the band, and 19 semis.

MR: Good Lord. And there's an east and west coast.

BK: And there's an east and west coast so you multiply that by two. So you're talking an army of people. There's about 130 people including drivers, that are with us, and then you figure you go to the local arena they have all the local riggers, pushers, all the people that help, all the stagehands, and then you have your concessions people and your people selling merchandise, your parking, all that stuff, so like all of a sudden it's like a huge industry that's built up around what we're doing. So it's just like —

MR: Do you have someone who doesn't perform to keep all this together? Like do you have an office?

BK: There's a management office, Night Castle Management, there's a tour manager, Elliot Saltzman, there's a lighting designer, Brian Hartley, there's all these people — Dave Whitman mixes the front of the house, the live sound, he's also the engineer on all the records, so live sounds like the record. And for the other coast he's trained the guy to do the mixing. So it's a huge collaborative effort to put up a show like that. And I toured from '99 through, when was my last tour, through 2009, so eleven years of touring.

MR: And was it mostly November-December?

BK: All of November and December. You can't really play before Halloween, and you can't really do it after New Year's. So it was basically putting together a tour, a major tour, that like most bands would rehearse for a couple of months to go out with that much technology, and then they would tour for one or two years. But we had to compress all that, and we only had two months to do that, and then the whole next year everything would change, all the effects, the lighting trusses, everything that moves. It was like just a huge undertaking.

MR: What was the biggest reason you stopped touring?

BK: I started burning out, you know, missing seeing my kids, you know, it's hard. And the tour was getting grueling and, you know, I never expected to be really playing live on arena stages, you know, I was expecting to be the guy, you know, producing and doing that stuff. But the way it worked out I was just out there. So I was 42 years old before I was on a big stage for the first time.

MR: Isn't that interesting, how that worked out.

BK: So up there, all of a sudden you're, oh wow. And you look at the video and you think you're moving, and you look at the video and you go oh, it looks like you're standing there, so you have to move more, and kind of get the visual performance and make the excitement happen. So it's like that was a total learning process. But I wasn't one of the guys who had been what they call "road dogs" that had been out there forever doing stuff.

MR: How old were your kids when you were doing that?

BK: My daughter, when we started the touring — my son was eight, my daughter was four.

MR: Did they have any idea what you did?

BK: Well they had an idea, you know, they knew I did music. They didn't really care. Eliza, my ex, she would tell them, "hey, Daddy's on TV." And they'd go, "yeah, so, who cares?" You know I remember my daughter coming to like the first concert and falling asleep. Or like I'd come backstage, and there was like one song where I would get a break in the whole show. It's like a two and a half hour show so I'm standing up there playing the whole thing, and the keyboards and drums are kind of the solid rhythm

section to keep it all together. It's not kind of a traditional thing. So it's very rhythmic keyboard playing so you're kind of holding things together. And I remember going backstage and like my son's sound asleep on the couch. So yeah. They didn't think it was cool until their friends thought it was cool, and then they go, "oh, maybe Dad's all right."

MR: I mean if you said now, if you told them about going on tour with the Who, etcetera, does that impress them?

BK: No. Because they've seen me at the high level, and the last eight years or so we've been having guests. So we had Roger Daltry on stage, and we did "Behind Blue Eyes" and a few Who hits. And so we've had all the big rock stars that have been around with that. So it kind of came full circle. I remember working with Greg Lake from Emerson, Lake & Palmer. He was one of the first special guests we had, along with Jon Anderson from Yes. So like in one year I had to do "Roundabout" live from Yes, which had never really been done before, with all the vocals, because we had eight singers so you can do [scats] with the little "Three Blind Mice" thing. And that's what it was. Actually I was talking to Jon and I said, "what was that you did?" And he said, "I just had 'Three Blind Mice' in my head." [scats] So he just wanted to get "Three Blind Mice" in there. And Greg Lake, the last time I'd seen him was at Rich Stadium, outside of Buffalo, where I grew up. They were doing the Brain Salad Surgery tour, which was in quad. And they were up there 20 feet in the air on the stage, so I was down in front looking up at them, and then the next time I saw them I was working with them and teaching them songs, and figuring out how to do "Karn Evil-9" live.

MR: How neat.

BK: So he was up there. Great guy, great guy. Just loves to play.

MR: Well I was trying to figure out, watching some of the video of TSO, there seems to be a lot of unison going on in a lot of the lines. Is that correct? Do some of the guitar things double with the violins?

BK: Yeah. Double the lead guitar and the violins double a lot. And sometimes the keyboards are in there too doubling.

MR: Yeah. And there's no music on stage, right? And there's no music stands?

BK: There's music stands for the string section, because seven of the strings would be local players. We take the lead violin player, who also runs all over the place on stage, you know they get to rock out. They memorize everything and they're also the conductor-leader for the string section. So all the parts are written out. I made up all the scores and stuff for it. And they rehearse earlier in the day for the show and just play through it and go over the tough spots. And we have a contractor, Steve Trudell, out of Detroit, who actually contracts all the local strings for us throughout the country. So he knows the

people that'll look like they're rockers and won't mind things exploding behind them. Because —

MR: Yeah. They've got to know what they're getting into.

BK: Well they do but it's gone everything from — I remember one time there was like a shower of sparks that comes down in one part of the show. And it's what's known as cold flame. You can put your hand in it and it's not going to burn you. But it was hot enough that the back rail wasn't quite enough distance between the string risers and that, or there might have been a breeze blowing or something. So the sparks fell down and landed on the rosin rag for one of the cello players. And it just burst into flames. But this guy was totally cool. He just like was playing along stomping out the thing with his foot while he's playing. It was hysterical. And then we had another time where there was a viola player that like the first little ball of flame went off and she just — boom — stood up and left. Boom — gone. So you have the full range of people as far as that goes. But after a few years you start getting the same people back all the time and they knew what the show was and they got into it.

MR: How the heck do you mic those instruments so that you can hear them and they can hear themselves. I guess anything's possible now.

BK: Well now, because it's easier with the lower stage volume, they have like a little monitor and then there's a — I forgot which mic we're using on it — but they're little clip-ons that kind of go on the bridge. Yeah, because they have to hear themselves, otherwise it's horrendous and out of tune, and a lot of it's doubled on keyboards. So if the string section is rocking and sounding good, they're really loud in the mix. And if they're not they're at the appropriate level shall we say.

MR: I was blown away. I mean I'd seen a little bit, but since I knew you were coming I've been watching it a little more. Everybody has the look to go with the whole shebang. It's got every sense going.

BK: Yeah. Paul is like really visionary on a lot of things. He's thinking up all the effects and everything he can, and then we try to make it work. And you know, he wants everybody to look like rock stars up there, and do it. And it comes across like that.

MR: Do you ever try to — are you a thinker ahead as far as how am I going to be in the music business in ten years? Can you do such a thing?

BK: You try to figure out where you're going. You'll work on projects that may take three or four years to come to light. And you're just constantly writing and it's constantly changing too. You kind of say, "oh, I want to try to get this to happen." It's like when TSO was starting we were like kind of going a Broadway track or doing rock opera stuff, and then this one song hit that kind of took it in another direction. And we followed that for a while and now we're coming back to try and produce the original shows. Some of

them might get released as TSO records, some might be produced differently. So the stuff comes around. It's not uncommon for something to be sitting around for 20 years before it makes it to Broadway or something like that. It's a long process and you keep going, plugging away at it. And you know, luckily Trans-Siberian has been very successful. We've sold up over seven million records now, and touring for over a million people a year. So luckily I have put away enough money to put the kids through college and I can last for a few years. I don't have to worry about being hand to mouth. Because that is like the biggest musician danger. Like most musicians you're always just going to the next gig so you can have enough money to eat and do what you're doing, you know, the ones that don't have steady jobs. So I'm just very lucky that I've been able to support myself for thirty-something years in the music business.

MR: I guess. What's your role with the group now?

BK: I'm just doing a little writing, kind of on the outskirts right now. And we'll be working more. We're developing something called rock theater, where we'll take — this year's the first year they're not doing "Christmas Eve and Other Stories" as the main show. They're doing "Lost Christmas Eve" which is the fourth CD, the third Christmas one. And also we toured "Beethoven's Last Night" and just maybe moving that to a more theatrical setting called — rock theater is what we're going for. So there'll be different productions.

MR: Was the idea of, when you say you might record some of this stuff, and what you've been doing the last couple of years, will they come out on CD?

BK: Yeah. CD's are still viable. Especially, there's a lot of people that don't deal with the internet and don't like it. They want a CD. They want the thing they can stick in their car. They don't want to deal with this little box. But then on the other side there's the kids that, they don't even want to have the little box, they just want it to stream to them. So it's kind of going that way. You know, different parts of the world are still very CD oriented, and then there's places where it's just all internet and all downloadable music.

MR: Right. What's your view on that?'

BK: I think it's going to go more and more downloadable just the way it is, with books and everything. It was like two years ago that they crossed the halfway point between electronic books and paper. So it's the same thing. The digital download you see becoming a greater number. And numbers in general are way, way down for people actually paying for it in any form, because it's so easy to steal it. And a lot of people, their only way to access music is like YouTube. You know, that's how most kids nowadays, if they want to hear a song they go to YouTube and look for it. So it's like figuring out what the new model's going to be. Everything's in transition right now.

MR: That's for sure.

BK: The person who figures it out will win.

MR: I bet they're trying, too.

BK: Yeah. I mean Apple was huge with the iTunes thing. They figured out how to make a ton of money for Apple, you know, but at least they're paying something to the musicians and the bands. It's a different world out there.

MR: Yeah. I found this quote from someone talking about TSO, I think one of the three of you: "fog it, light it, blow it up."

BK: That's Paul.

MR: That's Paul?

BK: Yeah. "Fog it, light it, blow it up." There's a lot of fog onstage, you know, ground fog through the whole show. Smoke comes in for some things, which, I mean you need smoke to be able to see the beams of light on the stage. If it's a clear, no smoke environment, you can't see the beams of light. You have to have some particles for it to shine off of.

MR: Well it's the obvious thing. I hadn't thought of that really.

BK: Yeah. So, especially with lasers and things like that. We have a lot of lasers in the show and they're all making patterns and stuff. But you can't see the beams, it loses most of the effect, it's just this little thing drawing on the far wall. But if you have smoke throughout the whole thing you need to do a fan with laser beams and it looks like a platform of light. Like if you were watching it from way up in the top of the arena it almost looks like you could slide down this platform of light to the stage. So it's very, very cool looking stuff. But yeah, you need the fog, and the lights, the lighting effects, very big on lights being in time with the music and being part of the music, so everything's moving in layers. And then blow it up is all the pyro and the flames.

MR: Has the fog over the years gotten easier to be in the midst of?

BK: I never really liked it that much. But it's part of the show. You've got to do that. In the really cold venues the flames are great because it just warms you up.

MR: "Hey bring those closer!"

BK: Yeah. And everybody says, "the lights are so amazing, what's it look like onstage?" And I'm going, "well it looks like my keyboard is red and my keyboard is blue, or I can't see my keyboard. That's how the lights are for me." But it's fun.

MR: Have you noticed a difference in working with the sidemen people, sidewomen people, working with schooled musicians and people who are mostly self-taught, how they absorb the music, how they memorize it, how they learn it?

BK: Almost everybody out there is a combination. I am. I had piano lessons when I was a little kid and then in high school I started teaching myself. My music teacher would say, as I wanted to get better, he said, "well try the Bach two part inventions." So I learned all

those, and then he gave me "The Well Tempered Clavier," and then I remember Emerson, Lake and Palmer came out with "Pictures at an Exhibition," and it had probably been out for a while but, you know, it was a record club thing. I think I bought "Tarkus" was their first record, because it had a little giant armadillo on it and I thought, oh that's a cool cover. And I just bought it because of the cover, and loved the music and then bought all their other records. So I discovered "Pictures at an Exhibition" and I brought it in. Michael Levy was the teacher in the Williamsville School District.

MR: Oh, near Buffao.

BK: Near Buffalo, where I grew up. And so I brought this piece in and he goes, "you know that's a piano piece." And I go, "it is?" You know, I had no clue. And he was really nice. He bought me the music so I started learning that, and then, you know I'd practice all the time and my chops were really getting strong on my own. And then when I got up here I thought I could take piano lessons, so Albert Bowen was one of the adjunct people. He lived down in Clinton, and he was a quasi-official person up here. And so I actually took piano from him for one year. He was a student of Horowitz, and I just learned a lot about classical technique and how to approach a piece. I learned a couple of Chopin etudes from him, and just learned a ton. And then I had to take my keyboard requirement at Hamilton, so I quickly passed that because I could play the scales, and I had to play scales in every key and know your basics there. And that took a few weeks. And then I was working with Steve Best, who is still teaching.

MR: Steve was here then?

BK: Yeah, yeah. Steve is — I love Steve, he's great. So then I went through all the open score reading and figured bass reading. So I think it was either one semester or two semesters I passed out of all that stuff and I still had like two more years I had to take. So he said, "do you want to learn how to play organ?" So I started taking organ lessons instead of the basic keyboard. And that was great. I loved it. I started learning how to play with your feet and like all the different fingering techniques for organ, which really came in handy for doing synthesizer work, because when you're playing legato lines on the organ you have to play a lot of finger substitutions to play legato. And, you know, you get piano players playing multi keyboards it's always nuit nuit — or they just put the sustain pedal on and it just becomes a mush. So I developed kind of my own technique. I even play piano with finger switches so I don't use the sustain pedal. So it became really solid and clean when I play a lot. So it was all stuff I learned here that I kind of applied in my own way. And, you know, then I picked up some orchestration stuff. You know if you think of string parts I'd be doing like pads and stuff like that. I'd always think of it in terms of four voices and never try to clutter up chords and open things up, and do smooth moves.

So, you know, a lot of, all your voice leading stuff you learn here, all that kind of stuff, it all comes in handy. So basically no knowledge is wasted.

MR: In your listening going from classical to rock, did you sort of bypass the blues and early rock and the 60's?

BK: Yeah. I did a little bit, with jazz. I remember getting a book just showing how the scales work and would practice arpeggios and stuff, but I didn't really do a lot with jazz at all so I kind of missed the blues-jazz thing. So I was like solid rock and classical were my things. And I combined really well with the TSO stuff.

MR: If someone called you to play a blues gig, do you do that kind of thing?

BK: I've never done one of those gigs, but it'd be fun. You know I've been playing a little bit, like over the last ten, twenty years, you just have to do some. So I can do a basic blues and get through it. But like I don't know all the standards. I'm horrible at memorizing stuff. And to come in and play all the standards? You know, I can re-learn things and learn fairly quickly, but I just don't have that kind of repertoire where you go to a party and they say oh sit down and play this. And it's like yeah, right.

MR: Okay. But you memorized all the patch bays in the Record Plant.

BK: Yeah I can do it. It's just that I never was in that world. And the only time I ever played in like cover bands was here, with my band Rogue.

MR: And what kind of material were you doing?

BK: Oh we did like everything from like "Secret Agent Man" to we played the Cars, we played a lot of Steely Dan, which does have jazz influences. I mean I can play an eleventh chord. I know what things are, but I just, like the old jazz standards I don't know at all.

MR: And did you play frat parties and that kind of thing?

BK: Yeah, we played all the frat parties, sometimes two or three in a weekend. And we did this — senior year in the spring they used to have a thing called Commons Carnival where the people who had Commons apartment, which used to be upstairs. Before they renovated everything there used to be an apartment upstairs, and that was like the most-sought-after place to live on campus. So whoever got number one in the lottery would get Commons apartment, because it was a big three bedroom apartment with a huge living room, and you're right in the middle of campus upstairs. And so they would do this big party. So we did — it was kind of like a Woodstock-esque thing. We were set up outside. I had a big PA system. I was always the guy that owned the PA, so I was in the band. There's always one guy that owns the PA. That was me. So yeah, you run around and set up stuff and like hope you can remember how to play the songs by the time it's all up and working.

MR: And then at the end of the night you get to tear —

BK: And you get to tear it all down at the end. Yeah. Everybody else is like drunk and leaving and you're like, "uh guys?" No by that time we had people that would help. But that was a great time. There's like all these old photographs. And one guy cut together a YouTube. We made a cassette recording of the day and it actually came out great. So that's still out there, you see it on YouTube and it's got like — there's this one, all the elms had died so the quad was wide open. It was like right outside South dorm is where we were set up. It was great. Just had a big stage set up — Voice of the Theater, with JBL's.

MR: It's really cool because I've interviewed a few Hamilton folks from the classes of the 50's. And they were doing the same thing, except they were playing Dixieland, they were playing upbeat jazz, but they were playing the frat parties, they would drive to Cornell to a couple of frats and all this stuff. That's really neat.

BK: Yeah, it was so much fun doing that. Yeah. Different days.

MR: Do you remember why you chose Hamilton?

BK: I remember coming here and liking it. I actually got a ride with a friend of mine down here. He was going to look at Colgate and my uncle had gone there, so I went to Colgate and then drove on to Hamilton and just really liked it. And I came back for an interview. I was a swimmer too, you know, the swim coach liked me. It appealed to me, and the application was really short. It was like one essay or something, and all the other ones you had to write a book for. And I hated writing.

MR: You hated writing and you came to Hamilton — a writing intensive program.

BK: I know, and they passed me out of freshman writing because like my grammar was really good, but in hindsight I wish they hadn't because —

MR: So you came here in '75?

BK: Yes.

MR: Do you remember what the tuition was?

BK: Tuition was under five thousand dollars. And we were in double digit inflation during that time so by the time I left it was over eight thousand. So in four years it almost doubled. And now it's gone up a little bit, since then.

MR: A little bit?

BK: Yeah, it's still the price of a nice car, like a really nice car is one year of tuition is how you have to kind of look at it.

MR: Would you consider having your kids come here?

BK: If they wanted to. Yeah.

MR: This is really fascinating stuff for me. What do you envision yourself doing — I mean like you came here for a month, and I'm sorry I didn't get to know you better before this month is up. But do you do this kind of thing more — is this something that is on your radar?

BK: Yeah. I always thought being a college professor is like the ultimate kind of retirement job. You know, it's got a great schedule and just being able, and I've always loved teaching people, whether it's one-on-one or working with people. I've taken interns and just shown them how to make things work. And I've always come and done like one-off classes where I'll come in and be the guest lecturer for the day. So I've been doing that for a long time. And the last time I did that was last year, I came up for one of Sam's classes. And I've known Sam. We were talking. It turns out I was one of the kids that got hired to help move Sam in. So I knew I'd met him when he first got here, but I didn't remember how. But it was because I was carrying the couch up the stairs with a couple of other guys who were music majors after I graduated. So it was like, and then I've been on the Performing Arts Committee for years and years. So I got to know them all through there too. So I was saying I'd love to do more of this. I really like the teaching, and he's getting to do a sabbatical and he's been really busy with the Theater/Art Complex, so he — first he said, "maybe you can take over for me when I leave," and then figured out this in-between thing where I'm just taking one of his sections of Topics in Music, so it just worked out fine. I could teach for a month doing Topics in Music, and I'm just teaching music in the commercial world, kind of giving them an idea of how things work, with unions and performing rights organizations, and the basics of how recording works, how you talk to recording engineers. Because if you're working in music you've got to deal with all this stuff at some point, at some level. So I just kind of did a broad overview of that, and then doing a songwriting workshop as well. So it's been wonderful for me.

MR: It's terrific that these students are getting the real deal from someone who's done it. Because sometimes in music schools the professors are sort of twice removed from the real world. At least that's been my observation. It's not that they're not good musicians, but they may not have experienced the real thing for any length of time. So I'm glad you got to do this. In fact I have, I can pick your brain on this. I have a couple of students now who, you know they wanted to go into music and they think they want to be in the recording end of things. We briefly brought up this idea of going to school to be an engineer. Is that the way to go?

BK: Not really.

MR: Okay, so?

BK: You can do it, like the degree is sometimes more important when you're going to another institution, but you're going to pay a fortune to basically come out and not be making money. You'll still be at the bottom. You'll know more. For me it makes sense to take maybe a short course or something like that. I remember when I first went to New York I was looking at like one of the recording schools, and you know it was like a two year program, and at that time it was going to cost twenty-something thousand dollars. And so

they had like a three month course at the New School, for three hundred bucks, where they just introduce you to stuff, you got to see the inside of a studio, get to touch a few mics, but most of it was from reading all the recording magazines, reading every book I could find on recording, seeing how all that worked, and then I got my unpaid job at Record Plant and used that as my school, and learned how to do stuff like that and worked up through there. I mean you can, some people do get a lot of the recording schools, but it's not a direct route. You still have to be persistent as hell. You still have to work really hard. And some of them cost now. You could buy your own recording set-up and put it together and learn Pro Tools, do all this stuff. And there's different ways to do it but there's like no magic bullet. Full Sail, they have great facilities and stuff like that. I actually hired a guy from Full Sail who is currently working for me as an engineer. But he's like, him, like a friend of his, and maybe one other person actually have jobs coming out of there. So it's not necessarily the best way to go. Some people it's great for, but there's no guarantee of what you're going to end up with in a job. There's one school out in Vancouver where they really teach you like old school how to engineer. I'm spacing on the name. It's Bob Ezrin, who produced "The Wall" and tons of other stuff, an old time great producer. He runs it with Garth Richards. And those guys have a pretty intense school where there's like a whole thing.

MR: But you'd still have to go to a major New York, Nashville, or you have to be where it's happening.

BK: It helps. I mean there are small pockets everywhere but in New York there's just such a huge pool of talent. And all the major studios are shutting down. There's very few left in New York, because everybody's doing it at home. So there are not as many opportunities for people to find a job in the industry. You know there's still a lot of film mixing, there's mixing for television, and there's all that kind of stuff as far as the engineering goes. But a lot of it is you just have to get out there and invent yourself. Like one of the exercises is set yourself a goal, make five steps to get there, if you change tomorrow. But you have to aim somewhere. You can't go, "I don't want to go, I don't want go." You have to say like, like for me it was like, I want to get a job at Record Plant. That was my goal. I did that. And then I said I want to try this. And then one guy, I can't remember his name, but the description of you get windows of opportunity that will open for you at various times. And they just open for a second. And you have to be ready to go through — it can be a door or it can be a window, you can use whatever analogy you want. But they open and they're there, and you have to be able to recognize it and be prepared to go through it at the time. So you need to have your chops up in every aspect and be ready to go. And it's not a normal nine to five life. You don't go, "sorry, got to go." You know. I'll get interns that'll say, "I've got to leave, I'm supposed to have dinner." And I'm like, "okay, you're

not going to be doing this." That doesn't exist if you want to do the real music side. That is more you're working at a TV station and moving one fader up and down at a time.

MR: I'm the nine to five guy — I'm the five to {midnight} you know? It's been fascinating for me. Thank you very much.

BK: Oh, my pleasure.

MR: Do you have any last — a rock band anecdote that you could share with us?

BK: Oh things happen on stage, a couple of things. One I had a spinning keyboard room, basically I could spin the whole thing around and I rigged the pedals that moved with it so I could play and move around in circles and figure out how to do that. And one time I spun it and it just went wo-wo-wo-wo-bam. Right over. It was in the middle of "Christmas Eve Sarajevo." They got it off and put it back in working in a few minutes but it was just like whoa. That was kind of funny. And then the other thing was the very first time I played Madison Square Garden we have a song called "Wizards in Winter," which is one of the ones I co-wrote. It goes [scats] and it starts off with a string patch in the right hand and piano on the other side, the lower keyboard. And we have this song called "Prince of Peace" which is just solo piano and singer. And it was originally in the key of A and I had to drop it down to F for the current singer that was singing it. And instead of re-learning it I just used the transpose button on the keyboard. And like last minute at the end of sound check he goes, "oh, can we run through that once?" You know, because everybody's nervous, it's the Madison Square Garden. And so I said, "sure," so I transposed it and played it, and he said, "okay that's all good." Forgot to transpose it back. And my keyboard tech didn't catch that either. So you know, the very first opening notes in Madison Square Garden it just went — what? And I jumped. Because it's always a major third apart. So it was — well it's what rock guys call jazz. So that was really special. So it took me a few seconds to figure that out. You know, it's the loudest thing in the mix, just boom, totally wrong.

MR: You had some polytonality going on.

BK: Yeah, major polytonality, yeah.

MR: I remember Sam Pellman came to a show in Syracuse once and he goes, "well this will be mostly tonal stuff, right? That I'm going to be hearing?" And I go, "well there's random bursts of atonality, but yeah, it's mostly tonal."

MR: Well thank you. It's been really very interesting.

BK: Oh, my pleasure.

MR: Lots of luck in your future projects. I hope you come back.

BK: Oh I hope so too. It's been fun. All right.